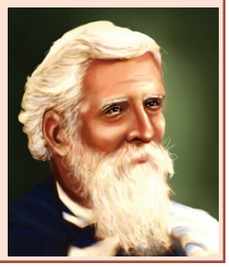
Dravidian and Non-Brahmin Identity

In 1801 Madras Presidency was formed by the colonial regime as a multilingual province (Tamils, Telegus, Malayalees, Kannadigas and Tulus). India's diversity could be noticed in the political developments of the Madras Presidency. In Bengal and in the rest of North India a Sanskrit and Vedic centered Indian culture was projected, besides an Indo-Aryan or Indo-German group of languages were acknowledged. Non-Vedic, Non-Sanskrit cultures were not recognized. The deciphering of Brahmi script in 1837 by James Principe and researches on south Indian languages (***Ellis in 1816 and Caldwell in 1856***) came to establish that Indian culture was not homogeneous; and there existed a (Non-Aryans) group of languages and countries.



Ellis is praised by Tamil enthusiasts as lover of Tamil, Valluvar, Kural and so on, without knowing the colonial and christian background of him. In fact, he tried to forge valluvar as Jain, to promote the "thomas myth" in India

Francis Whyte Ellis



Born: May 7, 1814, Clady, United Kingdom
Died: August 28, 1891, Kodaikanal, India

Robert Caldwell

Buddhist and Dravidian traditions also existed in India. In the south, especially in the multi-lingual Madras Presidency, theories on Dravidian group of languages and Dravidian cultural heritage led to assertion of Dravidian identity among the Non-Brahmin.

Two factors (1) Brahmins claiming superiority over Non-Brahmins and (2) Brahmins monopolizing educational and employment opportunities transformed the Dravidian identity into Non-Brahmin identity. (In Maharashtra too Mahatma **Jyotiba Rao Phule** launched a Non-Brahmin movement on similar lines). in the middle of 19th century Dravidian also indicated the Non-Brahmins in south India.



Jyotiba Rao Phule

The Non-Brahmins of the Madras Presidency had a grievance that the emerging nationalist leaders paid no heed to non-brahmin issues. In 1852 Gajulu Lakshmi Narasu Chetty expressed this grievance, seceded from British Indian Association and floated his own organization named Madras Native Association. In the post-mutiny period, the non-brahmin leaders undertook social reforms rather than political reforms. After the introduction of Minto-Morley reforms in 1909 the non-brahmin leaders of Madras Presidency began to protest the inadequate representations to them in education and employment.

11th Std Political Science Eng Medium Vol-2_Chapter 14.indd 266 2/5/2020 4:35:38 PM